

premise dominates the everyday behaviour of hackers. For sure, the computer has changed their lives, given it a focus, enriched it, while making it more adventurous. It has made hackers masters of a certain slice of the world. Since all this is so obvious to hackers themselves, they believe that surely everyone could benefit from experiencing this power. Surely everyone could benefit from a world based on the Hacker Ethic. This is the implicit belief of hackers, and they irreverently go beyond what is conventionally expected of computers—leading the world to a new way of looking at and interacting with computers.

The last two points of the traditional ethics perhaps do not seem surprising today. They must be understood in their historical context. In the 70s, computers were strange and unfamiliar to most people. In cases where they meant something, it was mostly to do with administrative data processing, computing centres, punch cards and Teletype interfaces. Art, beauty and life changes were not mainstream notions associated with computers.

The hacker attire

Hackers dress for comfort, function, and minimal maintenance rather than for appearances (some, perhaps unfortunately, take this to extremes and neglect personal hygiene). They have a very low tolerance for suits and other 'business' attire; in fact, it is not uncommon for hackers to quit a job rather than conform to a dress code. When they are somehow pushed into conforming to a dress code, they will find ways to subvert it, for example, by wearing absurd novelty ties. Most hackers I know consider a tie as a strangulation device that partially cuts off the blood supply to the brain...which explains the behaviour of tie-wearers. A tie could bestow upon you the reputation of a super-loser, a suit-wearing super-user with no clue—someone with root privileges on a UNIX system but no idea what he is doing; the equivalent of a three-year-old with an AK-47 for a toy. In times of dire stress, he may roll up his sleeves and loosen the tie about half an inch. It seldom helps.

Female hackers almost never wear visible make-up and many use none at all.

How to become a hacker

In his essay by the same name, Eric Steven Raymond lists out, among other things, the basic hacking skills for wannabe hackers. He recommends the following five languages—Python, Java, C/C++, Perl and Lisp.

Python. It is cleanly designed, well documented and relatively kind to beginners. Despite being a good first language, it is not a toy; it is very powerful and flexible, and well suited for large projects. Paul Graham points out that many hackers use Python because they like the way source code looks. That may seem a frivolous reason to choose one language over another. But it is not as frivolous as it sounds – when you program, you spend more time reading code than writing it. You push blobs of source code around the way a sculptor does with blobs of clay. So a language that makes source code ugly is maddening to an exacting programmer, as clay full of lumps would be to a sculptor.

Java. Eric Raymond suggests that Java is a good language to learn to program in. Most hackers today may not agree. Their main objection is that Java is not malleable. The malleability of the medium while programming is part of the process of discovery, which includes understanding all the requirements and forces—internal or not—that a system must be designed around. James Gosling, best known as the father of the Java programming language, in his paper 'Java: An Overview', says, "Very dynamic languages like Lisp, TCL and Smalltalk are often used for prototyping. One of the reasons for their success at this is that they are very robust... Another reason ... is that they don't require you to pin down decisions early on. Java has exactly the opposite property: it forces you to make choices explicitly."

The difference between languages like Lisp and Java, as Paul Graham points out in his book 'Hackers and Painters', is that Lisp is for working with computational ideas and expression, whereas Java is for expressing completed programs. As James Gosling says, Java requires you to pin down decisions early on. And

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